On the edge of an urban revolution?

Through the use of social media networks, the June protests gained size and strength, recruiting students and middle-class residents who had little prior experience of activism but were fed up with the ongoing processes. The sheer size of the mobilisations forced politicians to respond, and President Dilma Rousseff, Governor Sérgio Cabral and Mayor Eduardo Paes quickly responded by giving in to some long-standing demands from civil society in Rio. President Rousseff promised massive federal investments to improve the urban systems for collective transport. In a rush she also tabled a bill, approved by the Congress, ensuring that 75% of the future oil revenues were to be earmarked for the health and education sectors. Governor Cabral of Rio de Janeiro put on hold the demolition of public sports and school facilities adjacent to the Maracanã stadium. Mayor Paes declared a truce in his war against some of the communities resisting removal, such as in Morro da Providência and Vila Autódromo, and started negotiations with the community leaders. However, in a public statement on 8 August, the People's Committee stated that 'The recent retreats of the state government … are nothing more than reactions to the popular mobilisations. People taking to the streets have sent a clear message to politicians: we will not accept living in a city for sale! We will not accept a city managed for private benefit!'

This statement is most likely correct. The retreats of the state and municipal governments came after persistent public demonstrations and protests. Both Governor Cabral and Mayor Paes are facing demands for their impeachment, and they and others are feeling the pressure coming from the streets. However, the recent promises have been interpreted by some as mere reactionary fire-extinguishing politics; as a populist compliance with some of the demands of a population with a short memory. Civil society gained some small victories with the protests, but there have been no profound changes in the urban regime. The 'Olympic project' continued to dominate the city governance. The history of Vila Autôdromo, which has gone through numerous threats of removal and guarantees of permanence, shows that a promise today might very well be challenged in the future. Civil society will have to keep up the pressure to guarantee that the politicians stick to their promises.

'Rebel cities' are, according to David Harvey (2012), places where the right to the city is translated into 'the urban revolution'. In Brazil this urban revolution has but begun.